

The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People

Stephen R. Covey

THE ARGUMENT

Why do the techniques for being effective with other people keep failing, and what has to be true before any of them work?

Because effectiveness is not a technique. Two hundred years of American success writing were almost entirely about character until the early nineteenth hundreds, when the emphasis moved to personality: technique, image, how to appear to be rather than how to be. The techniques are not worthless. They are the tip of an iceberg, and they hold only as long as the mass underneath holds. What sits underneath is a set of principles that operate whether or not you believe in them, the way a farm operates. You can cram for a test, because a test is a social system with a grader in it. You cannot cram on a farm, and every part of life that actually matters is a farm. So the habits run in order. The first three win a private victory over yourself and carry you from dependence to independence; the next three win a public victory with others and carry you from independence to interdependence; the seventh renews all six. Until you are independent you cannot be interdependent, which is why every attempt to be effective with other people before you are effective with yourself comes out as manipulation, and is read as manipulation.

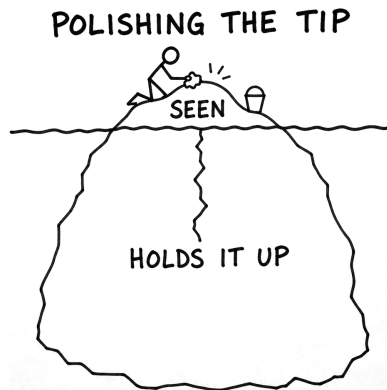
THE MATURITY CONTINUUM

The habits are sequential, and the sequence is the whole design. Picture a line from low maturity to high with three positions on it. Dependence is the attitude of you: you take care of me, and if you do not, I blame you. Independence is the attitude of I: I can do it, I am responsible, I can choose. Interdependence is the attitude of we. The habits move you along that line in order — you cannot do calculus before algebra.

- 1 **Be proactive** You are the programmer. Between what happens to you and your response there is a space, and in it the freedom to choose. Work inside your circle of influence, not your circle of concern.
- 2 **Begin with the end in mind** Write the program. Everything is created twice, mentally then physically, and the mission statement is the mental creation. Personal leadership: deciding what the first things are.
- 3 **Put first things first** Run the program. Personal management, and the test of integrity: living by the priorities habit two identified. A compass, not a clock. Its home is Quadrant Two.
- **Independence reached, interdependence now possible** One through three constitute the private victory. Until it is real, the next three become techniques, and techniques are detected.
- 4 **Think win-win** The habit of mutual benefit, and of abundance — there is plenty out there and to spare, so another person's strength is not a threat. The options are win-win or no deal.

- 5 **Seek first to understand, then to be understood** The sequence is the habit. The key to influencing someone is first to be influenced by them. Feeling understood is air; until people have it, nothing else reaches them.
- 6 **Synergize** The fruit of four and five. Differences stop being obstacles and become the raw material for a third alternative neither party arrived with. One plus one equals three, not one and a half.
- 7 **Sharpen the saw** Renewal in four dimensions — physical, mental, spiritual, social-emotional. It surrounds the other six and makes them repeatable.

INSIGHTS

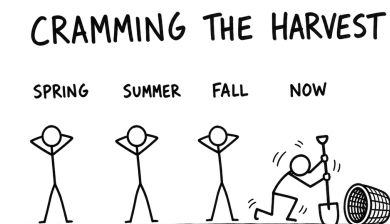


The techniques are the tip of an iceberg

Covey went back two hundred years into the popular success literature of the United States. For the first hundred and fifty years, almost the entire focus was on character: integrity, fidelity, courage, compassion, responsibility, justice, service. Then, in the early nineteen hundreds, the emphasis moved to personality — technique and image, how to appear to be rather than how to truly be.

A student asked Covey how he was doing in the class. Covey said, you know that far better than I do — how are you doing? The student admitted he had had a rough time and had not applied himself. He had come, Covey pointed out, to find out how well he had psyched out the system, when he already knew in his heart how he was doing.

- The techniques are not fraudulent and not useless. They are the part of the iceberg above the water, and they hold exactly as long as the mass below holds. Most development effort goes into the tip, because the tip is what other people can see. The seven habits run inside out: character first, then technique. Covey notes the shift is now running back toward character on pragmatic rather than moral grounds.



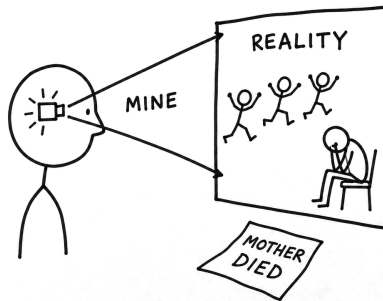
You can cram for a test but not on a farm

Ask a room of adults whether they crammed in school and the hands go up. Ask whether they got good at it and they stay up. Now ask whether anyone has crammed on a farm — forgotten to plant in the spring, coasted all summer, then worked frantically in the fall for a harvest. The question is absurd, and everyone knows instantly why.

A farm is a natural system, governed by principles rather than social convention. School is a social system with a grader in it, which is why cramming works there — you can get a degree without getting an education. Covey's claim is that a mind, a body, a marriage, a character and a reputation are all farms rather than tests, however much they get graded like tests along the way.

- This is what makes the habits unfakeable, and it relocates control. The popular language says you are the master of your own destiny. Covey's version is narrower: we control our actions, but the consequences that flow from them are controlled by principles, and accepting that is the only sense in which anyone is master of anything. It also changes what is worth teaching — a practice expires when the situation changes; the principle underneath it keeps applying.

YOU ARE THE PROJECTOR

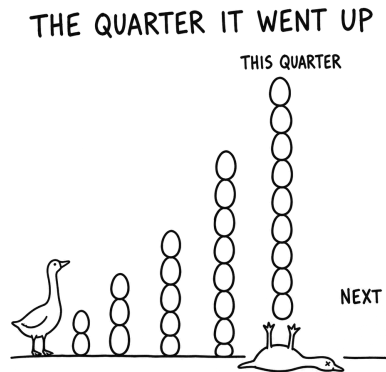


You are always describing yourself

A paradigm is the mental image you carry of the way things are, assembled out of your background and experience. It is not an opinion sitting on top of reality; it is what you take reality to be. We all think we see the world as it is. In fact we see the world as we are, and when you describe a person or a situation as though describing it as it is, you are describing your own frame of reference and projecting it outward.

Covey was on a subway one quiet Sunday morning when several children ran on, followed by their father. The children were wild — up and down the car, shoving people's newspapers aside. The father sat down beside Covey and did nothing at all. Covey held it in for a few minutes, then said, sir, do you think you could control your children a little, they're very upsetting to people. The man lifted his head as though he had only just arrived. Oh, yes, I guess I should. We just left the hospital and their mother died about an hour ago. I don't know how to take it, and frankly I don't think they do either.

- Nothing on that car changed. One sentence of new information arrived, and Covey's irritation was replaced by a wish to help — no effort applied to his attitude, none to his behavior. Attitude and behavior are downstream of the paradigm, which is why most development programs work on the two things that move last. The fastest way to change someone's behavior is to change how they see their own role. Anyone who has become a parent, or a manager for the first time, has watched the world reorganize overnight with no effort spent on attitude.



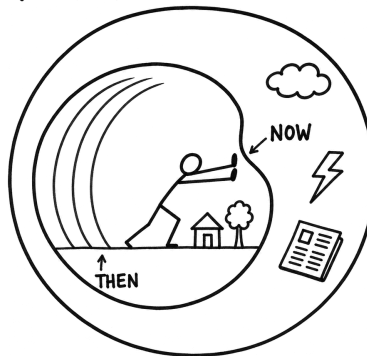
Every result is drawn against a capacity you cannot see

Aesop's farmer finds a golden egg beside his goose, then another, and another, and becomes wealthy — and impatient. He wants them all now, so he kills the goose to get at them, and finds none. That fable contains Covey's whole definition of effectiveness: getting what you want, and getting it in a way that lets you get it again and again. He calls it P/PC balance. P is production, the golden eggs. PC is production capability, the health of the goose.

Covey describes a clam chowder house so popular you could barely get near it between eleven and two. New management arrived, kept the name, and watered down the chowder. The bottom line rose for a month or so, because all the cost of the quality had been saved. Then the customer base liquidated itself, and people would not come back or believe it was the same chowder — the violation of trust outlasted the change in recipe.

- The asymmetry is what makes this hard to catch in time: cutting capability raises production first and lowers it later, so the early evidence always argues for continuing. Cut training, selection, research and every other form of people development, and you can double an organization's bottom line for a quarter or two. The same balance runs through a body, a mind and a marriage. Covey asks whether a man who went from nothing to hundreds of millions with a bankrupt family was effective — in the business sense perhaps, in the sense that matters on a deathbed, no.

PUSH FROM THE INSIDE



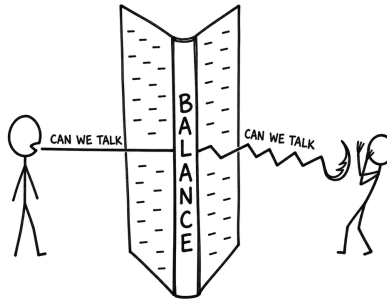
The circle you work in is the circle that grows

Between what happens to us and our response there is a space, and in that space lies the freedom to choose. Covey draws the practical version as two circles. The outer one, the circle of concern, holds everything you can do nothing about — the weather, world events, another person's temperament. The inner one, the circle of influence, holds what you can affect. Proactive people work in the inner circle; reactive people work in the outer one.

Covey spent four years as assistant to a president who was visionary, talented and dictatorial, whose staff felt treated as errand runners and sat in the corridor trading stories about him. One man, Ben, did not: the president's weaknesses were in his circle of concern, not his circle of influence. Sent for data, he anticipated the need, analysed it, added recommendations, and delivered it in a form the president could take to the board. Inside four years Ben was the second person in the organization.

- The paradox is that the inner circle is not a limit but a lever. Every hour spent inside it makes it larger; every hour spent in the outer circle — accurately, articulately, and about real faults — makes the inner one wither. Viktor Frankl, imprisoned in the Nazi death camps, called this the last of the human freedoms: the power to choose your response to any condition.

IT ARRIVES AS THE BALANCE



The balance decides what your words mean

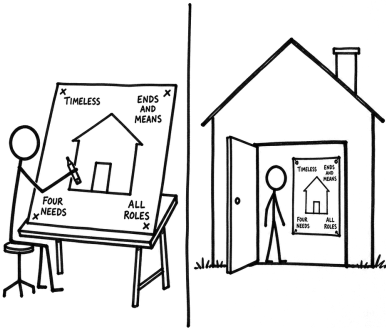
The emotional bank account is the trust built up in a relationship. Courtesy, kindness, honesty and kept commitments are deposits. Discourtesy, overreacting, cutting someone off, betraying a confidence and failing to keep commitments are withdrawals. With a reserve you can make mistakes and they are absorbed, because the other person already knows you care.

Now consider the overdrawn account. Communication stops working even when it is perfectly clear. People read between the lines, look for hidden agendas, ask how he is manipulating me. A small mistake gets blown out of all proportion. Covey describes the climate as walking on minefields and measuring every word — families and organizations living in memo haven.

- The account is why technique cannot be lifted out of context. The same sentence from the same person means opposite things at opposite balances, so a skill learned in isolation reads as a manoeuvre. And it moves in unglamorous currency: in relationships the small things are the big things. One deposit comes before all the others — understanding the other person from within their own frame of reference. Until you know what counts as a deposit to them, you will keep spending your own currency and wondering why the balance is not moving.

ACTIONS

BLUEPRINT BEFORE BRICK



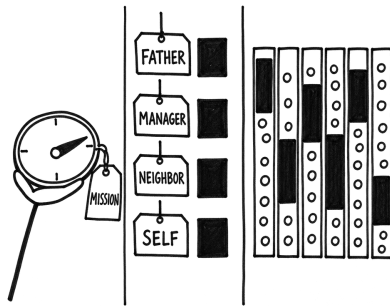
Write the mission statement, and write it as though it can never change

Take several weeks, not an afternoon. Write a statement of what your life is about, carrying vision — the picture of what you are about — and principles, how you go about it. Then hold it against four criteria. Timeless, so no goals in it: goals change with the situation and the mission statement is the part that does not. Both ends and means, since a worthy end cannot be reached by an unworthy one. All four human needs — to live, to love, to learn, to leave a legacy. And every role you hold, so no part of your life is left out of your own plan.

- Do the same for the family, and treat it as the more important of the two. Covey's family developed theirs over eight months with everyone participating, and used it afterwards as a family constitution, kept in the family room and returned to. He said the process mattered as much as the words. Three refusals are part of the method: do not rush it, do not announce or install it, and do not ignore it once written.

You do not invent a mission, Covey says, quoting Frankl — you detect it. So the work is listening rather than composing. A statement written quickly out of impressive words reads impressively and does nothing, because you will not recognise yourself in it when a real decision arrives.

ROLES INTO THE WEEK



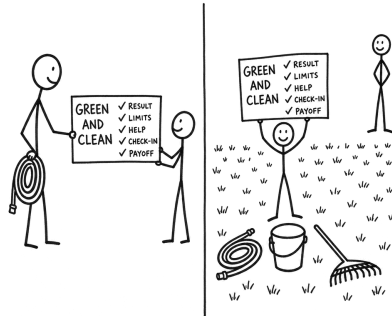
Plan the week from your roles, and let the calendar stay soft

Six steps, in order. Connect to your mission — the burning yes that gives you the ability to say no. Review the roles of your life; most are relationships. Select one or two goals for each role. Organize weekly: the week is the right unit, large enough for perspective and small enough to see how each day contributes, where a day is small enough that you end up prioritizing crises. Exercise integrity in the moment of choice — hard on principles, soft on scheduling. Then evaluate and adjust.

- The point of doing it by role is what lands in the week. Ask the two questions Covey asks audiences: name one activity in your personal life that you know, if done consistently and superbly well, would produce marvellous results, then name one for your work. The answers barely vary — preparation, prevention, planning, relationship building, deep communication with the key people. All of it is Quadrant Two, which is exactly why none of it is happening.

The reason to schedule the important things is not control, it is permission. Once your daughter's evening and your exercise are on the week, you can decline the urgent-but-unimportant without negotiating with yourself each time, and people who sense that orientation stop bringing you those requests. If it is your boss asking, note Covey's rule: what is important to another person must be as important to you as that person is to you — which promotes it rather than exempting you.

GREEN AND CLEAN



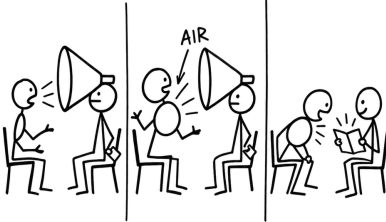
Delegate the result, never the method — in five parts

Set the agreement in five elements. A clear description of desired results, visual if possible, given real time. Guidelines, including the known failure paths — tell people where the quicksand is, but not which route to walk. Resources: who and what they can call on. Accountability: when you will review, and against what. And consequences, intrinsic or extrinsic, following from that accountability.

- Covey's illustration is his young son and the lawn. The job was green and clean — not watering, which is a method. Two weeks of training to establish what green and clean looked like. Who is your boss, son? You boss yourself. Who judges you? I judge myself. Then a fortnight of nothing: yellowing grass, garbage on the lawn. Covey wanted to order him out there and knew the cost — the moment you do, you kill the goose, and what happens tomorrow when you are not there? He bit his tongue and reaffirmed his purpose: raise boys, not grass. On the walk around the yard the boy broke down and asked for help; they filled two sacks. He asked twice more all summer, and the yard was better kept than it had ever been under Covey.

You cannot hold people responsible for results if you supervise their methods. That is the whole trade, and it means the hard part is not the setup but the fortnight of watching it not happen. Do not set the agreement in a rush, and never delegate when you are angry. Covey's experience was that where the relationship is good, people are twice as tough on themselves as you would dare to be.

AIR FIRST, THEN WORDS



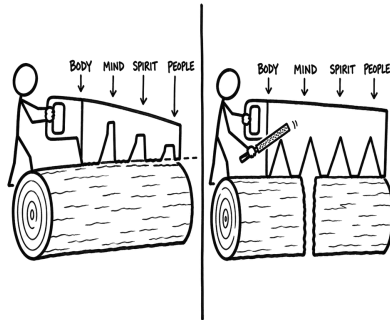
Listen until they would say you got it, then ask for your turn

In your next difficult conversation, do not prepare a reply while the other person talks. Lay aside your own views long enough to enter their world, and stay there until they would agree you have understood — their meaning, not your paraphrase of it. Then, and only then, ask to be understood in return. The sequence is the habit, and most people reverse it without noticing, because the tendency is to listen with the intent to reply.

- Covey's argument for why it works is physical. Take the air out of the room you are in and your interest in everything else vanishes instantly; get it back and it stops motivating you at all. A satisfied need no longer motivates. The emotional equivalent of air is feeling understood, and until a person has it, nothing else you offer will land. This is also the whole of influence: the key to having influence with another person is that they have had influence with you.

It cannot be run as a technique, and the failure is instructive. A professor friend of Covey's, desperate about a rebellious son, took the class and went home to say he wanted to understand. You have never understood me, the son said, and walked out. Covey told him the boy was testing his sincerity and had found the answer: you don't want to understand your boy, you want your boy to shape up. He went back to work on himself until it made no difference what the response was. What opened the door was not a listening move but an apology for having embarrassed the boy in front of his friends. The next day the father said, last night I found my son again.

FOUR TEETH ON THE SAW



Sharpen the saw in four dimensions, before the blade goes

Renew four dimensions on a regular schedule. Physical is exercise, nutrition and stress management. Mental is reading and writing — Covey suggests a book a month working up to a book a week, read outside your comfort zone, plus a journal and letters. Spiritual is private and everyone does it differently: working the mission statement, time in nature, the literature that inspires you, renewing your commitments. Social-emotional happens largely at home, in shared meals, traditions, laughter and listening.

- The leverage is the argument. A few hours out of a week of a hundred and sixty-eight affect the quality of every other hour. Covey says the main benefit of physical exercise is not fitness but what it does to your self-esteem and your sense of being in control, and the spillover into the other three dimensions. He argues, in the language of the stress researcher Hans Selye, that meaningful work produces eustress rather than distress, and that the stress of a repeatedly violated conscience far exceeds the stress of deadlines. The most powerful single move he names in the social-emotional dimension is to begin rebuilding one broken relationship — reach for the one that tests you most.

Habit seven sits in Quadrant Two, which is precisely why it is the first thing dropped: it never acts on you, so you must act on it. The man sawing the tree has been at it three hours; asked why he does not sharpen the saw, he says he is too busy sawing. Nothing about that answer is stupid. It is what urgency does to anyone who has not scheduled the alternative.

VOCABULARY

Covey builds the book on a handful of terms used with unusual precision. Several are ordinary words given a narrower meaning than usual, and the argument only holds if the narrow meaning is kept.

The character ethic

The success literature of roughly 1776 to 1926: integrity, fidelity, courage, compassion, responsibility, justice, service. Effectiveness as a consequence of what a person actually is.

The personality ethic

What replaced it — technique, image, public relations skill. How to appear to be rather than how to be. North Carolina's motto, to be rather than to seem, names exactly what was lost.

Principle

A natural law, like gravity: universal, self-evident, changeless, operating whether or not it is believed in. We control our actions; principles control the consequences.

Paradigm

The mental map you carry of the way things are, assembled out of your own conditioning and mistaken by you for reality. We do not see the world as it is; we see the world as we are.

P/PC balance

Production against production capability — the golden eggs against the health of the goose. Effectiveness is the ratio, not the size of either. Covey uses effectiveness rather than success deliberately.

The emotional bank account

The trust built up in a relationship. Courtesy, honesty and kept commitments are deposits; discourtesy, betrayal and broken promises are withdrawals. The balance decides how your words are heard before you say them.

Circle of influence, circle of concern

The inner circle holds what you can affect; the outer holds what you cannot. Energy spent in the inner circle enlarges it; energy spent in the outer one shrinks it. A reactive person can be extremely busy in the outer circle.

Quadrant Two

Important but not urgent: prevention, preparation, planning, relationship building, self-development, mission. The leadership quadrant, and the one displaced, because nothing in it announces itself.

Win-win or no deal

Mutual benefit, with the honest option of agreeing to disagree agreeably when no mutual win exists. Lose-win is not win-win; being nice while being taken to the cleaners is losing.

Synergy

The whole being greater than the sum of its parts — creative cooperation producing something neither party brought, and reachable only once both underlying purposes are on the table. Its negative form, where energy goes into fighting, produces less than one person working alone.

QUICK REFERENCE

THE SHAPE	1–3 are the private victory, dependence to independence. 4–6 are the public victory, independence to interdependence. 7 renews all six. The order cannot be swapped.
EFFECTIVENESS	P/PC balance — the golden eggs against the health of the goose. Getting it in a way that lets you get it again.
HABITS 1–3, THE PRIVATE VICTORY	Be proactive: between stimulus and response is a space; work the circle of influence. Begin with the end in mind: everything is created twice, so write the mission statement. Put first things first: compass, not clock; live in Quadrant Two.
HABITS 4–6, THE PUBLIC VICTORY	Think win-win: abundance, and win-win or no deal. Seek first to understand: feeling understood is air. Synergize: get to the underlying purposes, then invent the third alternative.
HABIT 7 — SHARPEN THE SAW	Physical, mental, spiritual, social-emotional. A few hours a week improve the other hundred and sixty.
FOUR MISSION-STATEMENT CRITERIA	Timeless, so no goals in it. Ends and means. All four needs — live, love, learn, leave a legacy. Every role you hold.
SIX-STEP WEEKLY PLAN	Connect to mission. Review roles. Set goals per role. Organize the week. Integrity in the moment of choice. Evaluate.
FIVE PARTS OF A STEWARDSHIP AGREEMENT	Desired results. Guidelines and known failure paths. Resources. Accountability. Consequences. Delegate the result, never the method.
DEPOSITS THAT COUNT MOST	Understand their frame of reference first. Promises sparingly made. Small kindnesses. Clear expectations. Loyalty to the absent. I-messages, not you-messages. Apology. Forgiveness.

The Chinese bamboo shows a bulb and a shoot for four years, and in the fifth grows eighty feet. All of the early growth went below the ground.